Upon Him, Not His Attributes: Yosef's Land, the Dweller in the Bush, and the Day Called G-d's Name

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Parshat Vezot Haberacha, 3rd aliyah — Devarim 33:13–33:17
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 60–65
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, middle of Epistle 20
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** Hilchot Kelim 9–11
- **Rambam (1 ch.):** Hilchot Gerushin 1
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 222 — the law of divorce by a written *get* (Devarim 24:1); Negative Commandment 357 — not to remarry one's divorced wife after she has become another's (Devarim 24:4)
- **Hayom Yom:** Tishrei 11, 5704 — after Yom Kippur 5556 in Lyozna the Alter Rebbe spoke on "Who is like the Eternal our G-d whenever we call upon Him": *eilav* and not upon His attributes; simple faith joins the essence of the soul to the Essence of the *Ein Sof*; He is the Healer of the ill and He Who blesses the years
- **Seasonal overlay (not a replacement of the daily cycle):** Omit *tachanun* and kindred passages. Begin working on — or at least planning — the sukkah immediately after Yom Kippur. Midrash: the four days between Yom Kippur and Sukkot are days in which Israel is "preoccupied with mitzvot… this one with his sukkah, this one with his lulav." Baal Shem Tov: the day after Yom Kippur is called "G-d's Name," without specifying which Name.

Seasonal frame. On Yom Kippur, 21 September 2026, the year was sealed. Hayom Yom of the ninth had already named the hinge: Erev Yom Kippur is *charatah* on the past; Yom Kippur is *kabbalah* for the future. The hinge turned. The fast ended. The blast was sounded. What remains is not another confession. What remains is a dwelling.

The calendar itself writes the sequence. On the tenth of Tishrei, in the year of the Calf, Moses descended with the Second Tablets. On the eleventh he gathered the people and opened the work of the Mishkan. The same date, in the Chassidic reading of the Baal Shem Tov, is not given one of the particular Names — not *Havayah*, not *Elokim*, not *Ado-nai* — but is called simply "G-d's Name." Particular Names describe particular worlds. "G-d's Name," without a specifier, is an effusion that does not stay inside one world. Yom Kippur touched the essence of the soul, which is one with the Essence. The day after is what that contact leaves in ordinary time: a Name that has not yet been narrowed into an attribute, and a people told to start building.

Elul trained a meeting in the Field. Rosh Hashanah seated the King. The Ten Days concentrated the nearness. Yom Kippur sealed. Today the Field is not cancelled and the throne is not vacated. Today the question is whether the seal will become a roof of branches — a house that admits rain, a house that does not pretend to be permanent, a house that still holds a Name.

The third aliyah of the last parsha is not accidental company for that work. Moses blesses Yosef. The blessing is land, dew, deep, sun, moon, ancient mountains, everlasting hills, the fullness of the earth, and "the favor of the Dweller in the bush." After a day spent without food or leather or washing, the Torah returns a people to produce, to soil, and to a Presence that inhabits matter without consuming it. That is already the grammar of a sukkah.

I. The Third Aliyah: Yosef's Land and the Dweller in the Bush

> *"And of Joseph he said: Blessed of the Lord is his land, with the bounty of the heavens above, with dew, and with the deep crouching beneath." (Devarim 33:13)*

Rashi: there is no land in Israel so full of good as Yosef's. All other lands need Yosef's; his does not need theirs. The "deep crouching beneath" is the tehom that rises to water it.

The blessing does not open with office. Levi, in the portion of 10 Tishrei, received Urim, teaching, and the altar. Benjamin received the House between his shoulders. Yosef receives land. After Yom Kippur that order is exact. Office without produce is a sanctuary that cannot feed the pilgrims who will sit in booths. A sealed year that does not become bread is a *kabbalah* that has not yet left the mouth.

Yosef is the son who stored grain through seven years of famine. The last parsha of the Torah, on the morning after the seal, names the steward. Judgment without provision is not the covenant. Provision without judgment is not the covenant either. Yosef held both: he named the coming scarcity, and he filled the storehouses before it arrived. Elul was the naming. The Days of Awe were the accounting. Today the storehouse is opened as blessing, not as ration.

> *"And with the bounty of the yield of the sun, and with the bounty of the crop of the moons." (33:14)*

Rashi: the land produces fruits ripened by the sun, and fruits that the moon ripens — vegetables that grow by night. Ibn Ezra reads the plural "moons" as months: produce in its season, month by month.

The verse will not let blessing be a single weather. Sun and moon, day-crop and night-crop, the visible heat and the quiet increment. A *kabbalah* taken at Ne'ilah that only functions in public light is not yet Yosef's land. Some of the year's fruit will ripen when no one is watching. Chinuch that only trains a child for the visible fast has not yet taught the night-crop.

> *"And with the first of the ancient mountains, and with the bounty of the everlasting hills." (33:15)*

Rashi: the hills were created before the other hills of the earth, and they pour their produce first. Sifrei hears in "ancient mountains" the patriarchs and in "everlasting hills" the mothers.

The land is not raw dirt. It is inheritance with a date. Mountains older than the year's accounting still give fruit this year. That is the right pressure on the morning after Yom Kippur. The seal does not invent the family. The seal asks whether this year's fruit will be worthy of hills that were already old when the Calf was danced. A father who treats the day after the fast as a private recovery has misread the hills. The hills are still producing. The children are still watching whether he will.

> *"And with the bounty of the earth and its fullness, and the favor of the Dweller in the bush. May it come upon the head of Yosef, upon the crown of the elect of his brothers." (33:16)*

Rashi: the bush is the thornbush of Shemot 3, in which the Shechinah revealed itself to Moses. "The elect of his brothers" — he was separated from them, sold, and still remained the one on whose head the blessing rests.

The bush is the theological center of the aliyah, and it is the hinge into the sukkah. A thornbush holds fire and is not consumed. Matter hosts Presence and remains matter. That is not a metaphor added to the season. It is the season's own claim. A sukkah is boards and cuttings. It is not the Temple. It is not even the Mishkan, whose work this date also begins. It is a house whose roof is vegetation, whose walls may shake, whose occupancy is seven days, and which is nevertheless a dwelling for the Name. The Dweller in the bush is the One who can sit in such a house without burning it down and without being reduced to wood.

Yosef is called *nazir echav* — set apart among his brothers. Separation here is not exile as punishment only. It is the condition under which a steward can feed the brothers who sold him. After Yom Kippur a Jew is, in a modest way, set apart: sealed, still a little emptied by the fast, already commanded to build. The blessing rests on that head, not on the head that never left the table.

> *"His firstling bull is majesty to him, and his horns are the horns of a re'em; with them he shall gore peoples together, to the ends of the earth. They are the myriads of Ephraim, and they are the thousands of Menasheh." (33:17)*

Rashi: the firstling bull is Joshua, who came from Ephraim, majestic in the conquest. The two horns are the two descendants who lead — Joshua from Ephraim, Gideon from Menasheh. Targum and later readers hear also the two tribes that Yosef became: a single house that holds a plurality.

The blessing does not end in produce. It ends in force that has a direction — *ammim yachdav*, peoples together, to the ends of the earth — and in two names inside one father. Limited power under higher law is not imposed on the verse from outside. Yosef does not receive a crown. He receives land, favor, and two tribes who will have to live as brothers after they have been counted separately. Jethro's advice, dated to this same day, will say the same thing in the language of courts.

II. Traditional Approaches, Held Together

Sifrei / Rashi. The blessing is geographic, agricultural, and historical. Yosef's territory is the richest. The bush is the thornbush of the commissioning. The bull and the horns are Joshua and Gideon. Peshat does not require a sermon. It requires that the last parsha of the Torah still know which land feeds the rest, and which Presence inhabits a bush without consuming it.

Ramban and Ibn Ezra. The paternal register continues. Haazinu was witness. Vezot Haberacha is gift. Sun and moon are seasons. The *nazir* is distinction, not monastic withdrawal. Function, not flattery.

Chassidus, on the bush and on this date. The Baal Shem Tov names the day after Yom Kippur "G-d's Name." Particular Names map onto particular *sefirot* and worlds. An unspecified Name is an effusion from the Essence that Yom Kippur touched. The Alter Rebbe's Hayom Yom for this date reads "whenever we call upon Him" as *eilav* and not upon His attributes: the *orot* as they stand in the vessels of Atzilut, or — in the Baal Shem Tov's sharper line — the G-dliness invested in those vessels, or — in the simple meaning the Hayom Yom insists upon — the Essence of the *Ein Sof*, of which every ordinary Jew has knowledge through simple faith. Davening with that faith joins the essence of the soul to the Essence. From that joining, He is the Healer of the ill and He Who blesses the years. The agricultural blessing of Yosef and the liturgical claim of Hayom Yom are one claim: the years are blessed from Essence, not from a departmental attribute of prosperity.

Maharal / Nefesh HaChaim line. A finite ridge can bear an infinite Guest. A finite bush can hold fire. A finite booth can hold the Name for seven days. The miracle is not that Heaven is large. The miracle is that earth is asked to host.

Synthesis for the day. Yosef is land that feeds after famine. The bush is Presence that does not consume its vessel. "G-d's Name" is Essence not yet narrowed into an office. Jethro is judgment that refuses to remain in one pair of hands. The Mishkan-donations of this date, and the sukkah begun today, are the same movement: after the seal, build a dwelling. *Charatah* named the rupture. *Kabbalah* bound a future. Today the future is given walls.

III. Tanya: Earth That Keeps Making *Yesh*, and the Light That Returns from the End

Iggeret HaKodesh 20 continues, still in its middle. The Alter Rebbe is tracing a third manner of descent of radiance. It manifests most clearly in the lowest creatures derived from Earth — lower than Fire, Air, and Water — because Earth reveals the power of *yesh me'ayin* that comes from the essence of *Ein Sof* light. Living beings were created in the Six Days and thereafter reproduce. Earth keeps producing vegetation from a spiritual growth-power that is not itself a plant. Seed arouses that power; it does not create it. The *mazal* that says "Grow!" after sprouting only increases what already is. The basic cause is the earth's vegetative power, insubstantial and spiritual, yielding physical growth.

Why here, at the bottom? The "feet" of *Adam Kadmon* end at the lowest level of *Asiyah*, in the element of Earth. Below that, the infinite *Ein Sof* light encircles the worlds with almost no interruption. The *kav* that ends at those feet radiates upward as *or chozer* — reflected light — with intensified impetus. Beginning is wedged in culmination. A glimmer of a glimmer of a glimmer in physical earth rises toward the *neshamah*-spark of *malchut* of *malchut* of *Asiyah*. That spark is actual Divinity from the exterior of the *kelim* of *malchut* of Atzilut. It is enough to keep revealing *Ein Sof*'s creative power as constant growth.

The fiat "Let the earth put forth grass" operates in infinitude. It is not a one-time grant. Some plants require *mayin nukvin* — arousal from below, a seed. Even then the disproportion between seed and tree is close enough to *yesh me'ayin* that the Alter Rebbe will not let the language go. And planted fruit, drawn by labor from below, surpasses what sprouts by

unearned gift. From this one understands the elicitation of supernal lights in all four worlds: they surpass, by far, the lights granted as an arousal from above without a human hand. That surplus is the purpose of man's creation.

The day after Yom Kippur could not have been given a more exact companion text. Kaparah is, in one respect, an arousal from above. The seal is gift. Tanya will not let the gift be the end of the sentence. The earth is still putting forth. The reflected light is stronger at the bottom than the unreflected beam. A seed — one board, one measurement, one child handed a hammer — is *mayin nukvin*. It is not nothing. It is also not the tree. The disproportion is the point. Service from below draws what the unearned gift did not yet give.

The bush of the third aliyah and the earth of Epistle 20 are the same theology in two registers. Matter hosts a fire it did not kindle. Earth yields a growth it is not. A sukkah hosts a Name it cannot spell.

IV. Tehillim 60–65: From Rejection to a Year Crowned

The daily psalms move the interior through six stations.

60. "O G-d, You have rejected us." A banner is still asked for. After a fast, the mouth that was closed is permitted to say that rejection has been felt. The psalm does not stay there. It asks for a banner to be given to those who fear Him.

61. "From the end of the earth I call to You." Hayom Yom's *eilav* is already here: the call is to Him, from a distance that does not disqualify the caller. A sukkah is, among other things, an end of the earth built in a courtyard.

62. "Only to G-d is my soul still." Silence after Ne'ilah is not emptiness. It is the soul waiting without a second address.

63. "My soul thirsts for You; my flesh longs for You in a dry and weary land." The body that fasted is named. Longing is not only *neshamah*. Flesh longs. The season that is about to seat that flesh in a booth of vegetation has already been told that flesh is a petitioner.

64. Hide me from the counsel of the wicked. Fidelity after the seal will be opposed. Yosef's horns were not decorative.

65. "Praise waits for You in Zion… You silence the roaring of the seas… You crown the year with Your goodness, and Your paths drip fatness." This is the psalm the morning after Yom Kippur has been walking toward. Zion is named. The seas are stilled. The year is crowned. Fatness drips on the paths — not only on the sanctuary. Yosef's land and Psalm 65 are one sentence. The agricultural blessing of the third aliyah is the psalm's last word made into territory.

A family table does not need all six. It needs 65. The year has been crowned. The paths can drip. Build the booth where that dripping can be sat under.

V. Rambam: Vessels That Still Function; a Bond That Cannot Be Cut by Speech

Kelim 9–11. Metal utensils contract impurity when they have an independent name and function. What is merely a hinge of a building does not. Pegs that serve wood are judged with the wood; pegs that stand as tools are judged as tools. A broken utensil remains susceptible so long as it can still perform its intended work. Breakage that ends the work purifies, unless the remnant is repurposed.

The morning after Yom Kippur is not a lesson in discarding the year. It is a lesson in asking whether the vessel still functions. A resolve spoken at Ne'ilah that cannot perform its work by 11 Tishrei is already close to a utensil whose teeth have been pulled from the comb. Repair is not impurity. Pretending that a ruined tool is still a tool is not honesty. Rambam's patience with remnants — a needle that can still sew, a key that can still turn — is the right patience for a *kabbalah*. Do not throw the year away. See what still turns.

Gerushin 1; P222 and N357. A woman is divorced only by a written *get*. The Torah sets ten principles: the husband must act voluntarily; the instrument must be written, not oral; it must sever jurisdiction; it must be written for her sake; transfer must follow; witnesses must stand; the purpose must be divorce. Speech does not dissolve the bond. A document, intent, and delivery do. The negative commandment forbids taking her back after she has become another man's wife. Some ruptures, once completed through a third party, are not reversible by sentiment.

The juxtaposition with the day after Yom Kippur is severe and useful. On Yom Kippur the mouth confessed. Today the law remembers that the most consequential unbindings in Israel are not accomplished by a mouth. They are written, witnessed, and delivered. A *kabbalah* that remains a feeling has the legal status of an oral divorce: it has not yet done the thing it names. Write it. Hand it to the week. Let someone see it. The sukkah is, in this register, a written *get* against the illusion that the seal was only inward. Boards are witnesses.

Jethro's counsel, dated to this day, belongs with Gerushin 1 more than it first appears. Moses cannot judge alone. Bonds and their dissolutions cannot remain in one throat. Distributed judgment is not bureaucracy. It is the refusal of domination by a single mouth — even a mouth that has just come down from Sinai with second tablets.

VI. Hayom Yom: Upon Him, and the Blessing of the Years

At the close of Yom Kippur 5556 in Lyozna the Alter Rebbe spoke, briefly as was then his way, on *Mi keilokei Elokeinu bechol kar'einu eilav* — "Who is like the Eternal our G-d whenever we call upon Him." The Sages: *eilav*, and not upon His attributes.

Pardes Rimonim: "upon Him" means the *orot* as they are invested in the vessels of the ten *sefirot* of Atzilut. The Baal Shem Tov: "upon Him" means the G-dliness invested in those vessels. The simple meaning the Hayom Yom will not surrender: "upon Him" is the Essence of the *Ein Sof*, of which every ordinary Jew has inherent knowledge through simple faith. "Close to him" and "whenever we call to Him" use the same *eilav*. One points to the Essence of the Infinite; one points to the essence of the soul. Davening with simple faith joins them. Then the Essence is the Healer of the ill, and He Who blesses the years.

This is why the day is called "G-d's Name" and not a particular Name. An attribute can be petitioned as a department. Essence is not a department. The ordinary Jew does not need to know which *sefirah* he is addressing in order to call. He needs *emunah peshutah*. The joining does the rest. Healing and the blessing of years are not side-benefits of a more advanced contemplation. They are what Essence does when it is called as Essence.

Yosef's land is the agricultural face of "He Who blesses the years." The bush is the theological face of a Name that inhabits a vessel. The sukkah is the architectural face of both. Simple faith is the avodah that costs no scholarship and admits no substitute.

VII. This Date in the Work of Building

Two events are assigned to 11 Tishrei in the year of the descent from the mountain.

First: Jethro finds Moses judging from morning to evening and tells him the truth that a prophet can miss when he is standing inside his own fidelity. "You will surely wear yourself out… you cannot do it alone." Appoint men of valor over thousands, hundreds, fifties, tens. Major matters come to you. Minor matters they will judge. They will bear the burden with you.

This is covenantal republicanism without a foreign vocabulary pasted on. Limited office. Graded courts. No undivided mouth. Non-domination as a family structure before it is a theory of states. A people freshly forgiven is not placed under a single exhausted judge. It is taught to share the weight. The day after the seal is already a day of institutions.

Second: Moses gathers Israel and opens the work of the Mishkan. They bring more than is needed. The Midrash will later say that the four days between Yom Kippur and Sukkot are days of preoccupation with mitzvot — sukkah, lulav. The first of those four days is also, in the origin-story, the first day of bringing for a dwelling. The continuity is not invented by later custom. From Second Tablets to boards and sockets is one night.

A sukkah is not a Mishkan. Treating it as if it were is a sentimental error. Treating it as if it were unrelated is a colder error. Both are dwellings commanded after a revelation that could have ended in speech. Both refuse to let the Presence remain only in the mouth that heard.

VIII. Practical Avodah and Chinuch

One act. Before nightfall, put one real measurement toward the sukkah: a board cut, a length marked, a sketch dated, a child sent to look at last year's *schach* and say whether it still shades. Do not let the day after Yom Kippur be only recovery. Recovery that does not become a dwelling is a fast that did not finish.

One interior. In *Shemoneh Esreh* today there is no *tachanun* to carry the old tone. Use that vacancy. Call *eilav* — not an attribute of mercy as a department, not an attribute of judgment as a residue of Yom Kippur. Simple faith. Join what Yom Kippur already disclosed: essence to Essence. Then ask, if asking is needed, for healing and for years. Hayom Yom has already said those two requests are native to that joining.

One sentence at the table. On Yom Kippur we were quiet, white, and hungry. Today we build a house whose roof is not ours. The Dweller in the bush can sit in wood without burning it. We can sit under branches without pretending we own the sky.

Chinuch, short enough for a child. - Yosef's land grew food when other lands did not. After a hard day, we still plant. - Hashem spoke to Moses from a bush that did not burn up. A sukkah is a bush we get to sit in. - Moshe could not judge everyone by himself. Even a great father shares the work. That is why you are holding the other end of the board. - We do not say the sad confessions today. We are too busy making a place.

Family first. The children do not need the *kav* and the *Iggulim*. They need a parent who slept, ate, and then stood up with a tool. Present fathering after a fast is already *or chozer*: light that reached the bottom and turned upward with more force than it had on the way down.

IX. Covenantal-Republican Resonance (Only Where the Text Gives It)

Three points, and no more.

1. **Jethro on this date.** Judgment that remains in one man is a form of domination even when the man is Moses. Graded courts are not a concession to weakness. They are the shape of a people who have just been forgiven and must not be swallowed by a single office.
2. **Yosef as two tribes.** Ephraim and Menasheh remain distinct inside one blessing. Unity that erases names is not the Torah's unity. A house can hold a plurality and still gore in one direction when the time requires it.
3. **Writing over speech.** Gerushin 1 will not let a covenant die by a sentence. Yom Kippur used sentences all day. The morning after insists that some of what those sentences meant now has to be built, witnessed, and handed over. Limited power under higher law includes the limit on what a mouth, even a holy mouth, can finish alone.

Geopolitics is not required. The text is already political in the older sense: it concerns how a people is judged, fed, housed, and named.

X. The Four Days

Vayikra Rabbah 30:7: between Yom Kippur and Sukkot Israel is preoccupied with mitzvot. This one with his sukkah. This one with his lulav. Four days. Today is the first.

Erev Sukkot is Friday. Sukkot I is Shabbat. The window is short and it includes a Shabbat of yom tov, which will freeze certain work. What is not measured today becomes a Thursday problem, then a Friday race. The Midrash's "preoccupied" is not atmosphere. It is a calendar.

The King is still seated. The Field is not cancelled. The Name that is not yet a particular Name is available to an ordinary mouth. Yosef's land is still putting forth. The bush is not consumed. Hammer.

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Daily study portals - Chabad Daily Torah Study - Sefaria

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